W11 Workshop Exercise: Video Games and Simulated Violence

Selection from:
Waddington, David (2007). "Locating the Wrongness in Ultra-Violent Video Games." *Ethics and Information Technology* 9:121-128.

p.127

Suppose that the protagonist in a violent video game slashes a computer-generated character to death with a machete. If a murder is committed in the real world, the individual is thrown in jail. However, when one commits a violent act within a computer game, the conventional wisdom is that there is nothing wrong with it. Of course, [redacted] ✶ [redacted] the conventional wisdom may incorrect. Nevertheless, the fact remains that an act, which is uncomfortably similar to acts which we would normally think of as wrong, is permitted within the context of a computer game. As video games increase in verisimilitude, and continue to up the ante in terms of violence, it will become increasingly difficult to differentiate between real transgressions (which everyone knows are wrong) and simulated transgressions (which everyone knows are OK). If one cannot differentiate between real transgressions and simulated transgressions, then one has to ***devalue the idea of wrongness***.

Essentially, I am arguing that wrongness can be devalued in the same way that money can. If a large supply of counterfeit money, which could not be distinguished from real money, were to enter the money supply, money would become less valuable. Likewise, if simulated acts were possible that look wrong, seem wrong, and thus cannot easily be distinguished from real wrong acts, wrongness becomes less useful as a moral value. In other words, it becomes devalued.

✶ This redacted bit is just blocking out text that might distract you. (It refers to claims made earlier in Waddington's essay.) I promise I'm not trying to shield you from dangerous ideas that might warp your fragile young minds!.

Background / Set up

State the argument in outline

Explain Any Rationales for the Premises

Evaluate the argument